

Annotated Research Brief

Title: School Attendance and Menstrual Health - A Rapid Assessment

1. Introduction

This rapid assessment was conducted in July 2023 across 10 schools in tribal Jharkhand to understand the relationship between menstrual health and school attendance. The study was commissioned by a local NGO in partnership with district health authorities.

[Annotation] Choice of 'rapid assessment' reflects urgency and resource constraints. Not as rigorous as a full evaluation, but useful for quick program feedback.

2. Methods

Data was collected using a mixed-methods approach: structured questionnaires with 120 girls aged 12-16, and 5 focus group discussions (FGDs) with teachers and peer leaders. Schools were purposively sampled to represent different geographies.

[Annotation] 'Mixed methods' enhances triangulation. Note the purposive sample - this limits generalisability but is appropriate for exploratory design.

3. Key Findings

- 63% of girls reported missing at least one day of school during their last menstrual cycle.
- Only 41% reported having access to sanitary pads at school.
- FGDs highlighted fear of staining, teasing by boys, and lack of disposal facilities as major barriers.

[Annotation] Quant findings are paired with qualitative insights - useful to capture both prevalence and underlying causes.

4. Limitations

Findings are based on self-reported data, which may be biased by recall or social desirability. The sample is not representative at the district level.

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[Annotation] Transparent discussion of limitations increases trustworthiness. Flagging non-representativeness avoids misuse.

5. Program Implications

- Prioritize disposal-friendly toilet infrastructure in schools.
- Expand peer-led menstrual education clubs.
- Engage boys and teachers in destigmatization efforts.

[Annotation] Links evidence to specific, actionable steps. Avoids generic 'raise awareness' framing.